

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



**CHARMED:** Snake charmers can help in conservation efforts

# THE HISS OF DEATH

**The rise in snake bite fatalities, partly due to the unavailability of drugs, has led to indiscriminate killing of reptiles by people, driving many species to the brink of extinction**

■ By Subhash Mishra

**A**fter earning for itself the informal title of India's corruption capital, Uttar Pradesh has been credited with yet another undesirable 'achievement'—one of the highest death rates from snake bites in the country. According to the state's official records, over 4,000 people bitten by snakes die every year. Those who survive the bite, die subsequently due to the inadequate first aid and unscientific treatment administered.

This, when India is neither home to most of the venomous snakes in the world nor to a dearth of anti-venom drugs and medicine. There are just over 50 species of venomous snakes in the country but that does not explain the high rate of deaths from snake bites. Australia, for example, houses

100 of the 250 known species of venomous snakes but curiously records only one death in a year.

The problem lies in the fact that most doctors in Uttar Pradesh, especially in rural areas, are not adequately equipped to handle snake bite cases. The government hospitals and community health centres lack the proper methodology to assist patients and administer first aid. Thus people are left with no other option but to kill the animal as soon as they see it.

This has raised alarm bells for wildlife conservationists, who see these 'mindless killings' as a danger to many species. "The killing of snakes may lead to the extinction of some of the most majestic species, like the cobra and python," says Jose Louise, who works with the Wildlife Trust of India. He adds that there is a

need to educate people about the fact that not all snakes are harmful and most only bite when attacked.

Most snake bites are, in fact, innocuous and are delivered by non-poisonous species. The venom is produced and stored in paired glands below the eyes of the reptile. Hollow fangs, located in the upper jaw, help discharge the venom. The amount of venom in a bite depends on a number of factors—the time elapsed since the last bite, the degree of threat the snake feels and the size of the prey.

With a huge demand for snake hide in international markets, the animal is smuggled out of the country for making handbags, coats and accessories. The snake sellers find it easy to locate potential buyers in the fashion industry, where the reptile is being used increasingly as an accessory.